Two Stories about Flying

The big idea

This chapter has two short stories. **His First Flight** by **Liam O'Flaherty** is about a young seagull who overcomes fear and learns to fly. **The Black Aeroplane** by **Frederick Forsyth** is a mysterious story about a pilot saved in a storm by a strange black aeroplane. Both are about **courage, fear and trust**.

Part I: His First Flight

Summary

- The young seagull is alone on his ledge. His two brothers and his sister have already flown, but he is afraid — his wings seem too weak to support him over the vast sea.
- His parents scold him, threaten to let him **starve** unless he flies, and his family taunts him for being a coward.
- A full day passes; he is very hungry. He sees his family eating fish on the plateau. His mother picks up a piece of fish and flies towards him with it, then stops just out of reach.
- Maddened by hunger, he **dives at the food**. He falls outwards and downwards, screams with fear, then his wings spread outwards and he begins to **fly**. His family flies around him, praising him.
- He lands on the green sea and is surprised that he does not sink. His family feeds him with fish — he has made his first flight.

Themes: fear of the unknown; self-confidence; parents' "tough love"; hunger as motivation; the first step is the hardest.

THE TURNING POINT

Hunger made him forget his fear. The mother's trick of holding back the fish was not cruelty but wise parenting.

Character of the young seagull: timid, lacking confidence, afraid at first, but capable — he only needed a push.

Part II: The Black Aeroplane

Summary

- The narrator is flying his old **Dakota** aeroplane over France to England, at night. He is happy, thinking of his holiday and a big English breakfast.
- He sees huge **black storm clouds** ahead. He has very little fuel, so he cannot go around them. He decides to take a risk and fly into the storm.
- Inside the clouds everything goes black. The **compass** and other instruments stop working, and the **radio** goes dead. He is lost.
- Suddenly he sees another aeroplane with **no lights**, a black aeroplane. The pilot waves and signals him to follow. The narrator obeys "like an obedient child".
- He is guided out of the clouds and sees two lines of runway lights. He lands safely with almost **no fuel left**. When he turns to thank the other pilot, the black aeroplane has vanished.
- He asks the woman in the **control tower** who the pilot was. She says there was **no other aeroplane** in the sky that night. The mystery is never solved.

Themes: courage and risk; the mysterious and the supernatural; help in danger; trusting a guide.

THE PILOT'S MISTAKE

The narrator says he should not have flown into the storm. He "took the risk" because of the attractions of home and a holiday — a lesson about impulsive decisions.

NOT A DREAM

Do not write that the pilot was dreaming. The story leaves the black aeroplane's identity a mystery; the point is the unexplained help.

Comparing the two stories

	His First Flight	The Black Aeroplane
Fear of	the vast sea, falling	the storm, being lost
Help came from	the mother seagull	a mysterious pilot
Theme	self-confidence	trust and the unexplained

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was the seagull afraid? How did his mother make him fly? Why did the pilot take the risk? What was strange about the black aeroplane? Who was the mysterious pilot — give your opinion.

Quick recap

- His First Flight (Liam O'Flaherty): fear → hunger → dive → flight.
- The Black Aeroplane (Frederick Forsyth): Dakota, storm, dead instruments, mysterious guide, no plane on radar.
- Common thread: overcoming fear; help comes when we most need it.

Practice questions

1. Why did the young seagull not fly with his brothers and sister?

   (a) His wings were injured (b) He was afraid his wings would not support him (c) His parents stopped him (d) He was too young

2. What finally made the young seagull fly?

   (a) His father's praise (b) A strong wind (c) Hunger, when his mother held a fish just out of reach (d) His sister's advice

3. What aeroplane was the narrator flying in "The Black Aeroplane"?

   (a) A jet (b) A Boeing (c) A helicopter (d) An old Dakota

4. Why did the pilot fly into the storm clouds instead of around them?

   (a) He wanted adventure (b) He did not have enough fuel to fly around them (c) The control tower told him to (d) He did not see the clouds

5. What happened to the instruments inside the storm?

   (a) They worked perfectly (b) The compass and radio stopped working (c) Only the radio worked (d) The fuel gauge broke

6. What did the woman in the control tower say?

   (a) The black aeroplane landed before him (b) The black aeroplane was a military plane (c) There was no other aeroplane in the sky that night (d) She had guided him by radio

7. The young seagull was surprised when he landed on the sea because

   (a) he did not sink (b) the water was warm (c) he saw a fish (d) his family left him

8. How did the young seagull's mother help him overcome his fear?

9. Who do you think helped the narrator in "The Black Aeroplane"? Give reasons.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. b 5. b 6. c 7. a 8. see notes 9. see notes